

The Cognitive Battlefield

Mastering Influence Literacy for Analysts



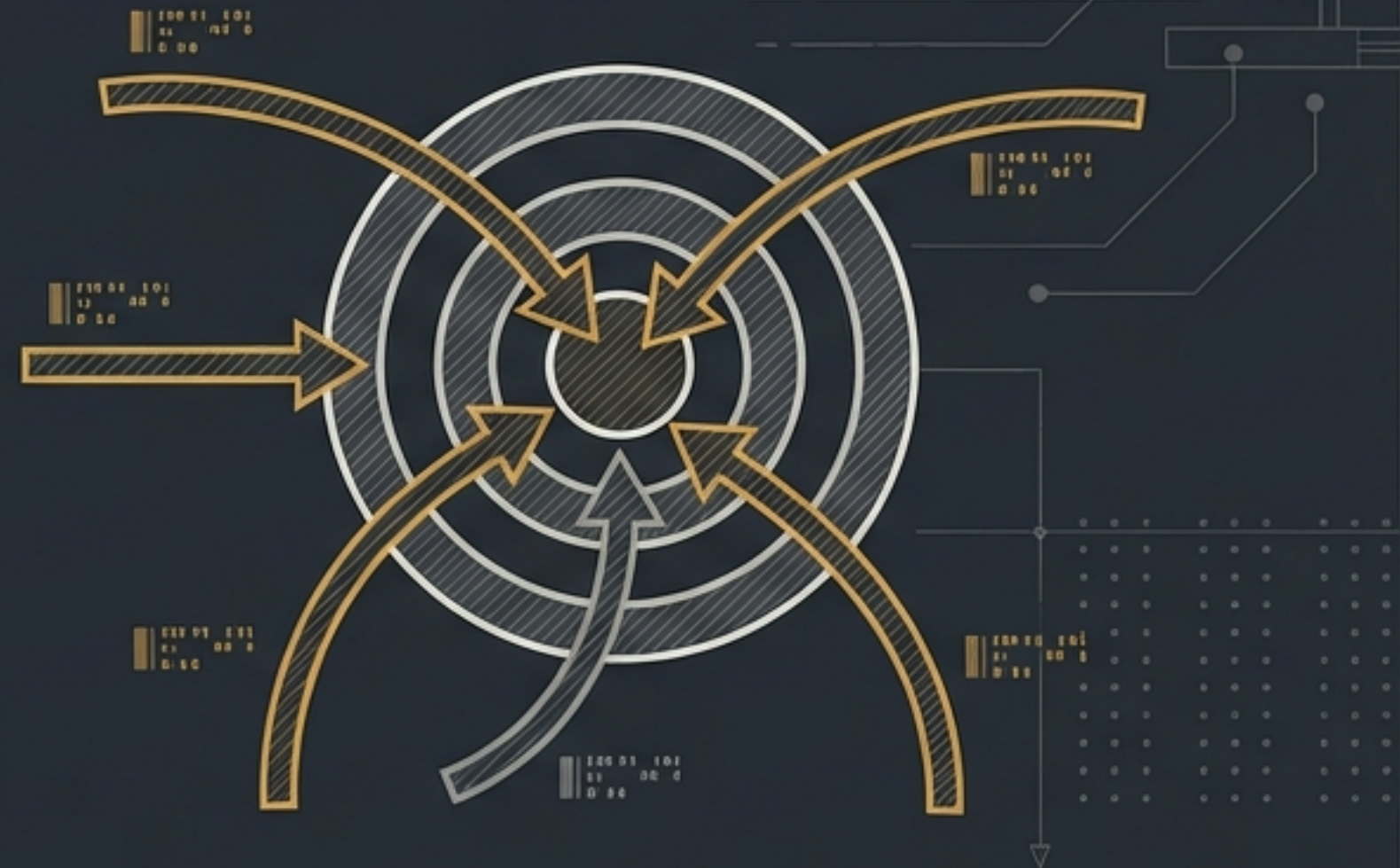
Influence literacy moves beyond fact-checking to analyze behavioral steering

The Baseline (Media Literacy)



Is this information true?

The Overlay (Influence Literacy)



- How is this message trying to move me?
- Toward what action, identity, or allegiance?

Persuasion leverages predictable cognitive shortcuts and choice architecture

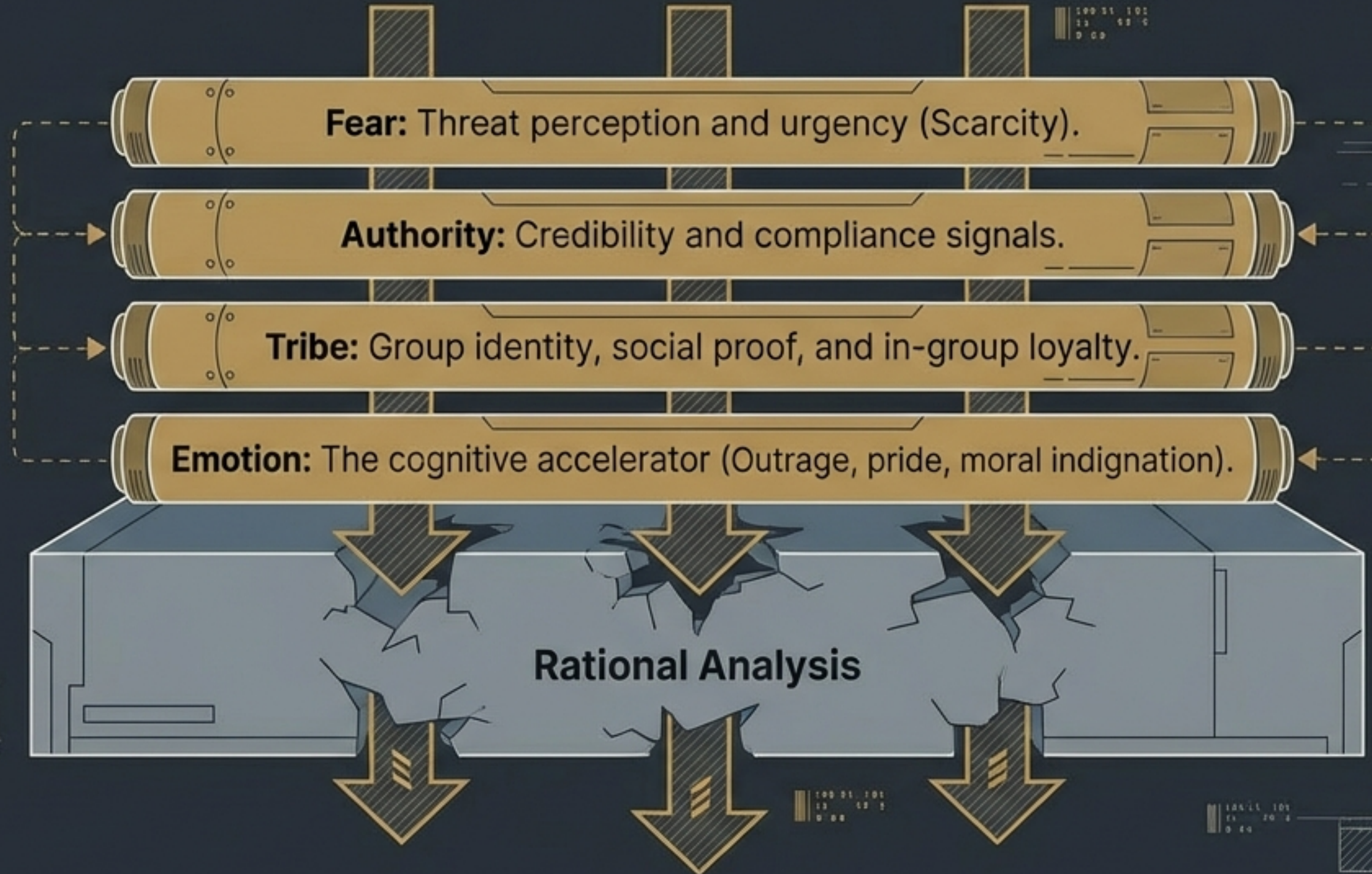
Cognitive Shortcuts (Cialdini)

Reciprocity
Commitment
Social Proof
Authority
Liking
Scarcity
Unity

Choice Architecture

Defaults
Friction
Salience
Cadence

The FATE model provides the emotional engine that bypasses rational analysis



The 7 Pillars framework systematically deconstructs influence operations

Detect, Analyze, and Respond to influence efforts across media, organizations, and politics.

The 7 Pillars of Influence Literacy

Framework to Detect, Analyze, and Respond to Influence Efforts



Pillars 1 & 2 isolate the operational intent and target audience vulnerabilities



Target Profile

1. Intent & Behavioral Objective:

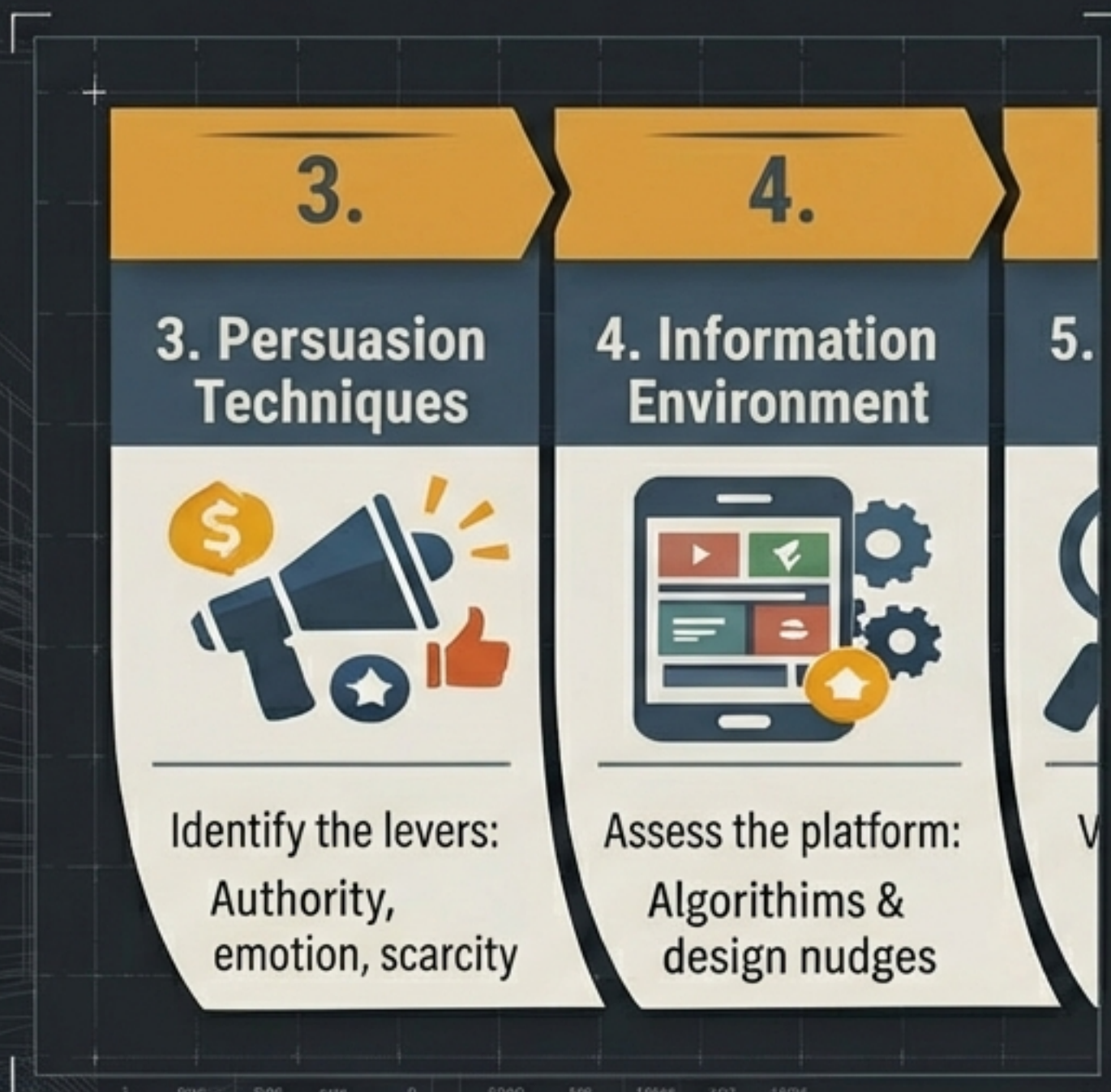
Defining the "next click." Is the goal compliance, mobilization, polarization, or institutional distrust?

2. Audience & Identity:

Mapping vulnerabilities. Identifying the "tribe" being recruited and the social emotions (humiliation, pride, resentment) being leveraged.

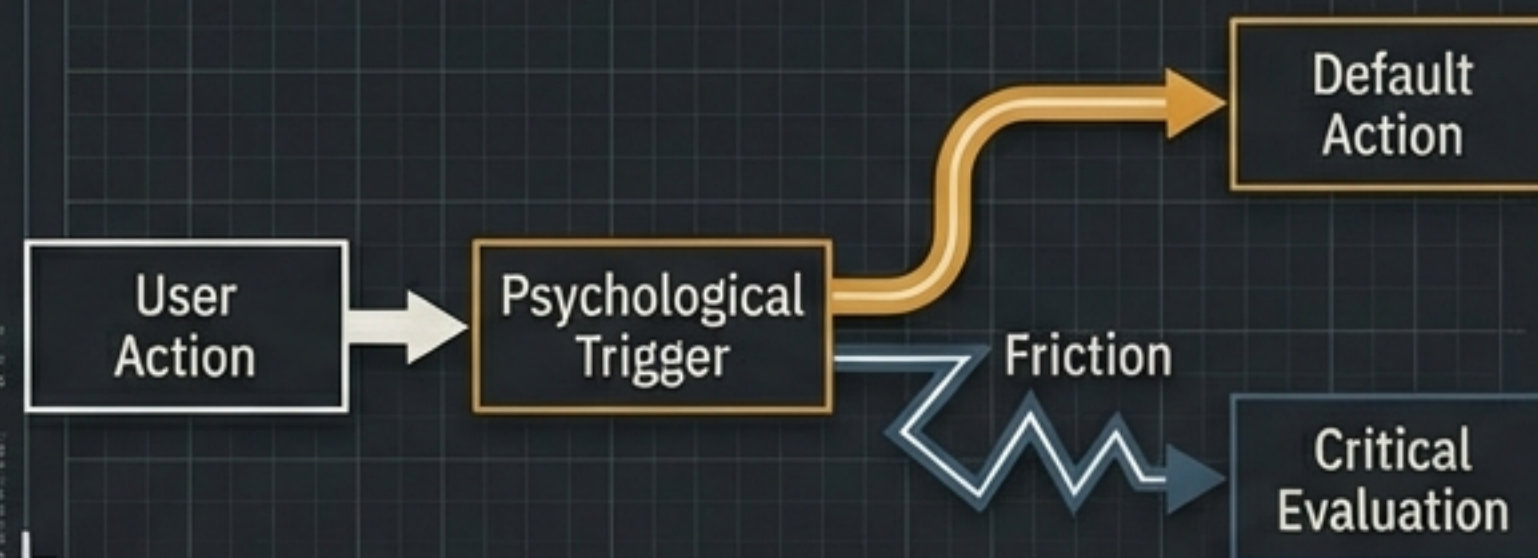


Pillars 3 & 4 reveal the psychological levers and environmental design nudges



3. Persuasion Techniques: Identifying the dominant lever (e.g., authority borrowing, manufactured urgency) and the credibility scaffold.

4. Information Environment: Mapping the choice architecture. What is the default behavior? What is salient versus hidden?



Pillars 5 & 6 evaluate epistemic discipline and map distribution networks

5.

5. Evidence & Truth



Verify the facts:
Source quality
& reliability

6.

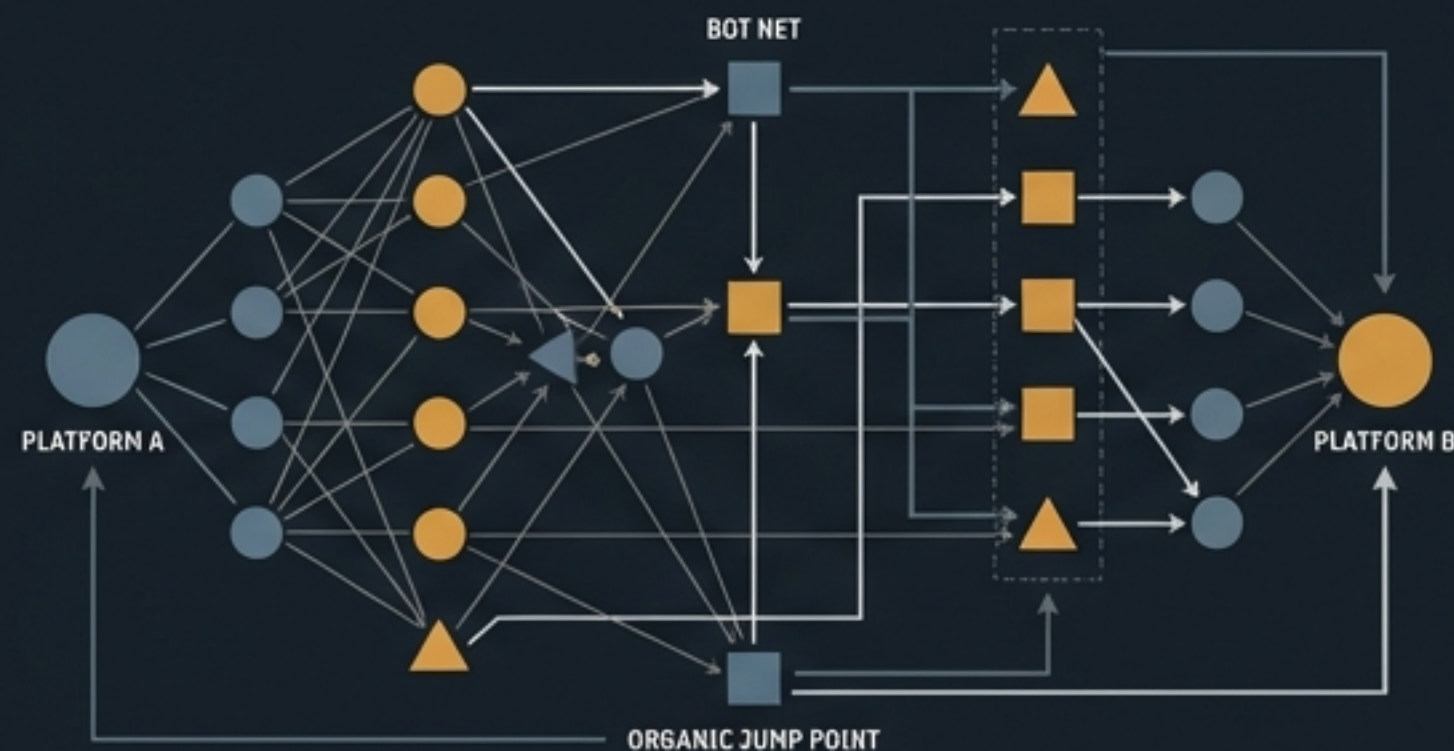
6. Distribution Patterns



Track the spread:
Bots, networks,
amplification

5. Evidence & Truth: Assessing epistemic posture. Commitment to reality vs. commitment to effect (e.g., the 'firehose of falsehood').

6. Distribution Patterns: Identifying coordination signatures. Tracking organic jump points versus synchronized framing shifts, bot amplification, and phrase fingerprints.



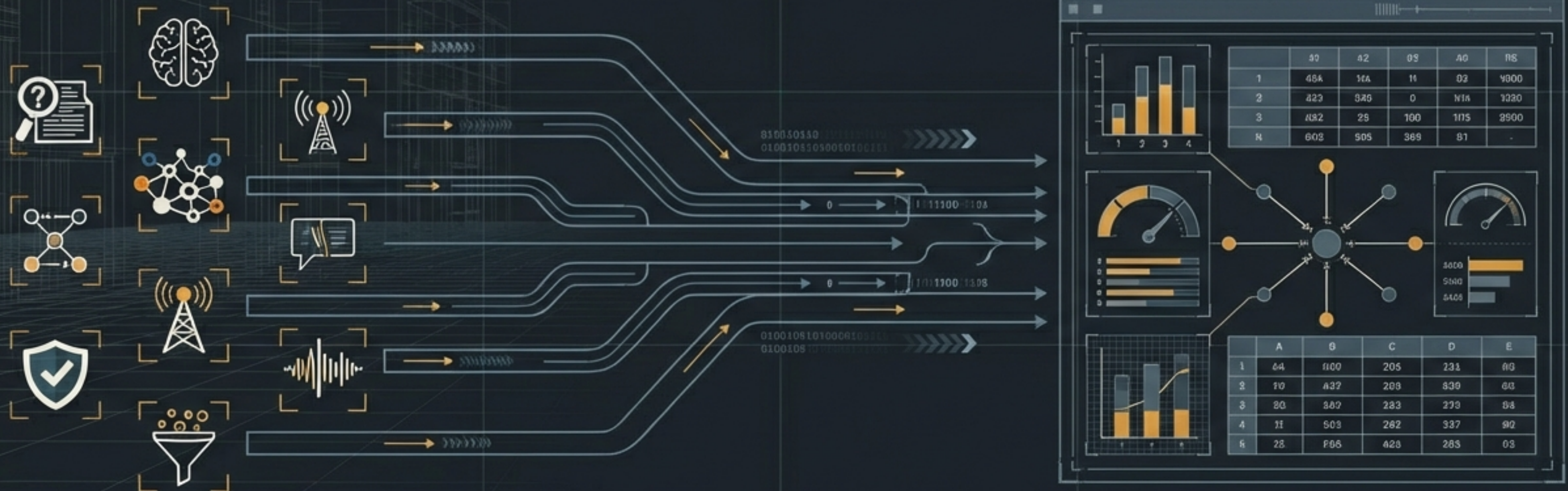
Pillar 7 shifts from detection to active defensive countermeasures



- Prebunking: Building mental antibodies by exposing tactics before they land.
- Reframing: Breaking the villain-hero trap to restore complexity.
- Friction Interventions: Slowing distribution to reduce harm.
- Trust Anchors: Deploying local validators over generic institutional voices.

Operational tradecraft translates theoretical frameworks into analytical action

Moving from passive message consumption to active, structured evaluation.
Integrating Influence Literacy with Structured Analytic Techniques (SATs).



The 9-Signal System provides an early warning radar for narrative manipulation

Real-time observable signals indicating structured influence efforts:

1. Emotional
Activation

2. Urgency
Framing

3. Authority
Signaling

4. Social Proof
Amplification

5. Identity
Framing

6. Moral
Polarization

7. Narrative
Simplification

8. Repetition
& Amplification

9. Behavioral
Direction

The Detection Matrix scores content to identify coordinated influence signatures

INFLUENCE LEVER	SCORE (0-3)
Identity Lever	3
Social Proof Engineering	2
Urgency and Scarcity	3
Reality Commitment	1

0-10: **Normal Persuasion**
(Monitor if high stakes)

11-20:
Manipulative/Exploitative
(Apply verification/friction)

21+: **Coordinated Influence**
(Map network, deploy targeted countermeasures)

The CARVER-I model prioritizes influence threats for operational triage

C - Criticality: Impact if the narrative succeeds.

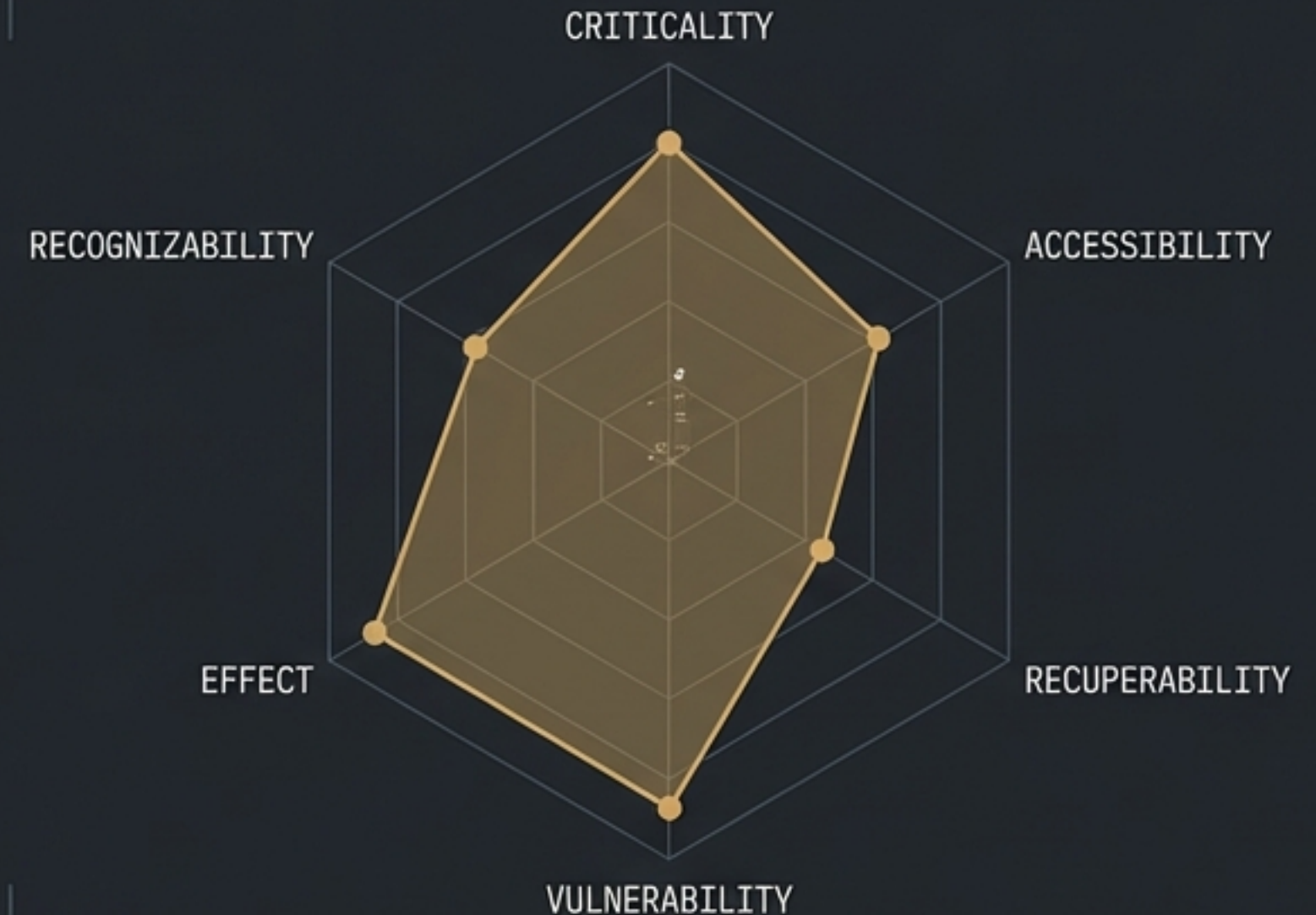
A - Accessibility: Ease of reaching the target audience.

R - Recuperability: Ability of the environment to recover trust.

V - Vulnerability: Audience susceptibility and bias alignment.

E - Effect: Observed traction and offline conversion.

Rz - Recognizability: Stealth vs. obvious manipulation.



RISK SCORE: 24/30 - PRIORITY CAMPAIGN

OPERATIONAL STATUS: ACTIVE THREAT ANALYSIS

Analysis of Competing Hypotheses evaluates competing narrative interpretations

Testing the evidence collected via the Detection Matrix against competing hypotheses:

Evidence	H1: Organic viral event	H2: Financially motivated astroturfing	H3: State-sponsored disinformation campaign
Sudden cross-platform framing shift	—	+	+
Bot network amplification detected	—	+	+
Highly sophisticated impersonation of local media	—	+	+

Narrative warfare mapping establishes robust indicators and warnings

